



**NED
DEBATING
SOCIETY**



NEDMUN VI

02 03 04

JANUARY



NED University of Engineering & Technology (Main Campus), Karachi

NEDMUN VI



UNITED NATION SECURITY COUNCIL

- A) Towards Reconciliation: Addressing the Israel-Palestine Conflict
- B) Stabilizing the Horn of Africa: Addressing the Conflict and Humanitarian Crisis in Ethiopia (Tigray region)

Agenda A: Towards Reconciliation: Addressing the Israel–Palestine Conflict

I. Introduction to the United Nations Security Council

A. Mandate and Authority of the UNSC

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) derives its mandate and authority from the Charter of the United Nations, which legally binds all Member States. Under Article 24 of the UN Charter, Member States confer upon the Security Council the primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security, authorizing it to act on their behalf in fulfilling this duty. In exercising this mandate, the UNSC has the authority under Article 39 to determine the existence of any threat to peace, breach of peace, or act of aggression and to decide appropriate measures to address such situations. These measures may include non-military actions, such as economic sanctions and diplomatic restrictions under Article 41, or, if deemed necessary, military action under Article 42. Furthermore, according to Article 25, all UN Member States agree to accept and carry out the decisions of the Security Council, making its resolutions legally binding. Collectively, these provisions establish the UNSC as the most powerful UN organ responsible for safeguarding international peace and security.

B. Functions and Decision-Making Powers

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is responsible for maintaining international peace and security and exercises a range of functions and decision-making powers to fulfill this mandate. Its primary functions include identifying threats to peace, investigating disputes, recommending solutions, and authorizing measures to prevent or stop conflicts, both peaceful and coercive. The Council can impose non-military measures, such as sanctions, trade embargoes, or diplomatic restrictions under Article 41, and, if necessary, authorize military action under Article 42. It can also establish and oversee peacekeeping missions, monitor ceasefires, and refer situations to international judicial bodies, such as the International Criminal Court. Decisions of the UNSC are generally made by vote, where each of the 15 members has one vote, and substantive decisions require the affirmative vote of nine members including all five permanent members (P5), granting them an effective veto power. Procedural matters, in contrast, require only nine affirmative votes without the possibility of a veto. These powers enable the UNSC to act as the UN's primary authority on international peace and security.

C. Role of the UNSC in the Israel–Palestine Conflict

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) has played a pivotal role in the Israel–Palestine conflict by seeking to maintain peace and address acts of aggression while upholding international law. Since the conflict began, the UNSC has adopted numerous resolutions calling for ceasefires, withdrawal of forces, and protection of civilians, such as Resolutions 242 (1967), which emphasized the “inadmissibility of the acquisition of territory by war” and called for Israel’s withdrawal from occupied territories, and Resolution 338 (1973), which called for an

immediate ceasefire and the implementation of Resolution 242. The Council has also monitored the situation through peacekeeping and observer missions, such as the United Nations Truce Supervision Organization (UNTSO), and has urged negotiations towards a two-state solution in line with international law. However, decision-making in the UNSC has often been constrained by the veto powers of the permanent members, particularly in politically sensitive instances, which has sometimes limited effective enforcement of resolutions. Despite these limitations, the UNSC remains a central platform for diplomatic engagement, conflict management, and the articulation of international consensus on the Israel–Palestine issue.

II. Introduction to the Agenda

A. Understanding Reconciliation in International Conflicts

Reconciliation in international conflicts refers to the process by which parties seek to restore relations, address grievances, and build sustainable peace after prolonged disputes or hostilities. It goes beyond mere ceasefires or peace agreements, focusing on healing historical, political, social, and economic wounds that often perpetuate conflict. Reconciliation involves several key elements, including acknowledgment of past injustices, apology or reparations, institutional reforms, and the establishment of mechanisms for truth-telling, justice, and accountability, such as truth commissions or international courts. In the context of the United Nations, reconciliation is often facilitated through diplomatic mediation, peacekeeping missions, and multilateral frameworks, aiming to create conditions for long-term stability, cooperation, and coexistence. Effective reconciliation not only addresses immediate conflicts but also prevents relapse into violence and strengthens regional and international security.

B. Scope and Significance of the Israel–Palestine Conflict

The Israel–Palestine conflict is one of the most enduring and complex disputes in modern international relations, with profound regional and global implications. Its scope encompasses territorial disputes, security concerns, human rights violations, and political sovereignty issues, affecting millions of civilians in both Israel and the Palestinian territories. The conflict has triggered numerous wars, uprisings, and humanitarian crises, drawing in neighboring countries and prompting international involvement. Its significance lies not only in its immediate human and geopolitical consequences but also in its impact on broader Middle East stability, global diplomacy, and the operations of international organizations such as the United Nations. The dispute has served as a focal point for debates on self-determination, international law, and the right to security, making it a critical issue for peacebuilding, conflict resolution, and multilateral cooperation worldwide.

C. UNSC Jurisdiction and Limitations

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) holds primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security and has jurisdiction over matters that pose threats to global stability, including armed conflicts, acts of aggression, terrorism, and breaches of international law. Its authority is derived from the UN Charter, particularly Chapters VI and VII, which empower the Council to investigate disputes, recommend solutions, impose sanctions,

authorize military action, and establish peacekeeping operations. However, the UNSC's jurisdiction is limited in several ways: it cannot directly legislate for Member States outside its mandate, its decisions may be constrained by the veto power of the five permanent members (P5), and enforcement often depends on Member States' willingness to act. Moreover, the Council's interventions are generally restricted to issues deemed international rather than purely domestic, and political considerations may affect its ability to act uniformly in all conflicts. Despite these limitations, the UNSC remains the only UN body with legally binding authority over matters of international peace and security.

III. Historical Background of the Conflict

B. Origins of the Israel–Palestine Conflict

Ottoman Rule and British Mandate Period

The territory of Palestine was part of the Ottoman Empire from 1517 until the end of World War I in 1917. During Ottoman rule, the region was largely agrarian, with a mixed population of Muslims, Christians, and Jews, coexisting under Ottoman administrative and legal structures. The empire maintained relative stability, although nationalist movements among Arabs and Jews began to emerge in the late 19th century, including the rise of Zionism, which sought the establishment of a Jewish homeland in Palestine. Following the Ottoman defeat in World War I, the League of Nations granted Britain the Mandate for Palestine (1920–1948), officially giving Britain administrative control over the territory with the goal of preparing it for self-governance. The Balfour Declaration of 1917, in which Britain expressed support for a Jewish national home in Palestine, became a central point of contention, fueling tensions between the growing Jewish immigrant population and the indigenous Arab population. During the British Mandate, both communities engaged in periodic violence and political struggle, laying the groundwork for the eventual partition plan and subsequent conflict after 1947.

United Nations Partition Plan (1947)

The United Nations Partition Plan was adopted by the UN General Assembly on November 29, 1947 (Resolution 181) as an attempt to resolve the ongoing conflict between Jews and Arabs in Palestine. The plan proposed the division of Palestine into two independent states—one Jewish and one Arab—while designating Jerusalem and Bethlehem as an international city under UN administration due to their religious significance. The Jewish leadership accepted the plan, viewing it as a legal pathway to establish the State of Israel, whereas the Arab leadership and surrounding Arab states rejected it, arguing that it violated the rights of the majority Arab population and was unfair in territorial allocation. The rejection of the plan led directly to civil conflict between Jewish and Arab communities and eventually escalated into the 1948 Arab–Israeli War following Israel's declaration of independence. The Partition Plan remains a landmark in international diplomacy, illustrating the UN's role in attempting to mediate complex territorial disputes and establishing principles for self-determination and international oversight.

Creation of Israel and the 1948 Arab–Israeli War

The State of Israel was formally declared on May 14, 1948, following the expiration of the British Mandate for Palestine. This declaration immediately triggered the 1948 Arab–Israeli War, as neighboring Arab states—including Egypt, Jordan, Syria, Lebanon, and Iraq—invaded the newly established state, supporting the Palestinian Arab population that opposed Israel’s creation. The war resulted in significant territorial changes, with Israel gaining more land than was originally allocated under the UN Partition Plan (Resolution 181, 1947). Approximately 700,000 Palestinian Arabs were displaced, an event referred to as the Nakba (“catastrophe”), creating a long-standing refugee crisis that continues to impact the region today. The conflict ended in 1949 with armistice agreements, establishing temporary borders known as the **Green Line**, but it did not resolve the underlying tensions, laying the foundation for decades of subsequent wars, occupation disputes, and ongoing negotiations between Israel and Palestine.

B. Major Wars and Escalations

The Six-Day War (1967)

The Six-Day War, fought from June 5 to June 10, 1967, was a pivotal conflict between Israel and the neighboring Arab states of Egypt, Jordan, and Syria. Rising tensions, including military mobilizations, blockades of Israeli shipping routes, and mutual distrust, escalated into a brief but decisive war. Israel launched preemptive strikes against Egyptian airfields, achieving rapid air superiority and then advancing on multiple fronts. By the end of the conflict, Israel had captured the West Bank and East Jerusalem from Jordan, the Gaza Strip and Sinai Peninsula from Egypt, and the Golan Heights from Syria, dramatically altering the territorial landscape. The war had far-reaching consequences: it intensified the Palestinian refugee crisis, led to the occupation of territories still contested today, and set the stage for future conflicts and UN interventions. The UNSC responded with Resolution 242, calling for “withdrawal of Israeli armed forces from territories occupied in the recent conflict” and the recognition of every state in the region’s right to live in peace, forming the basis for subsequent peace negotiations.

Yom Kippur War (1973)

The Yom Kippur War, also known as the October War, occurred from October 6 to October 25, 1973, when a coalition of Egyptian and Syrian forces launched a surprise attack on Israel during Yom Kippur, the holiest day in the Jewish calendar. The attack aimed to regain territories lost by Arab states during the Six-Day War of 1967, namely the Sinai Peninsula (from Egypt) and the Golan Heights (from Syria). Despite initial Arab advances, Israel mobilized rapidly and regained lost ground, resulting in a militarily inconclusive but politically significant outcome. The war prompted intense international diplomatic efforts, leading to UN Security Council Resolution 338, which called for an immediate ceasefire and the implementation of Resolution 242, emphasizing negotiations for a just and lasting peace. The conflict highlighted the fragility of Middle East stability, the risks of escalation involving global powers, and underscored the UNSC’s role in mediating ceasefires and facilitating peace talks.

Intifadas and Gaza Conflicts

The Israel–Palestine conflict witnessed significant popular uprisings and localized wars beginning with the First Intifada (1987–1993), a largely civilian-led uprising against Israeli occupation in the West Bank and Gaza Strip, characterized by protests, civil disobedience, and clashes with Israeli forces. This period catalyzed international attention and set the stage for diplomatic efforts such as the Oslo Accords (1993). The Second Intifada (2000–2005) was more violent, marked by armed attacks, Israeli military operations, and increased casualties on both sides. In the subsequent years, repeated Gaza conflicts—notably in 2008–2009, 2012, 2014, and beyond—have involved escalated exchanges between Hamas and Israeli forces, leading to significant humanitarian crises, displacement, and destruction of infrastructure. These uprisings and conflicts have underscored the protracted nature of the dispute, the difficulties in implementing peace agreements, and the challenges faced by the UN Security Council, UNRWA, and other international actors in protecting civilians, mediating ceasefires, and promoting long-term reconciliation.

IV. Legal and Political Framework

A. Relevant United Nations Security Council Resolutions

Resolution 242 (1967)

Resolution 242, adopted unanimously by the UN Security Council on November 22, 1967, in the aftermath of the Six-Day War, is one of the most important legal frameworks for resolving the Arab–Israeli conflict. The resolution emphasized the “inadmissibility of the acquisition of territory by war” and called for the withdrawal of Israeli armed forces from territories occupied during the conflict. It also affirmed the right of every state in the region to live in peace within secure and recognized boundaries and urged a just settlement of the refugee problem. Resolution 242 became the foundation for subsequent peace negotiations, including the Camp David Accords (1978) and the Oslo Accords (1993), and is frequently cited in UNSC debates as a guiding principle for a two-state solution. While its language, particularly regarding territorial withdrawal, has been subject to differing interpretations, the resolution remains central to international diplomacy regarding Israel and Palestine.

Resolution 338 (1973)

Resolution 338 was adopted by the UN Security Council on October 22, 1973, during the Yom Kippur War, which saw Egypt and Syria launching a surprise attack on Israel to reclaim territories lost in the Six-Day War (1967). The resolution called for an immediate ceasefire and the start of negotiations aimed at establishing a just and durable peace in the Middle East, explicitly urging the implementation of Resolution 242 (1967) as a framework for these negotiations. Resolution 338 reinforced the principle of “land for peace”, emphasizing the withdrawal of Israeli forces from occupied territories and the recognition of all states’ right to live in peace within secure and recognized boundaries. It became a cornerstone for subsequent peace processes, including the Camp David Accords (1978) and later diplomatic efforts between Israel and Arab states, illustrating the UNSC’s role in conflict mediation and the enforcement of international law.

Resolution 2334 (2016)

Resolution 2334 was adopted by the UN Security Council on December 23, 2016, addressing ongoing Israeli settlement activity in the occupied Palestinian territories, including East Jerusalem. The resolution reaffirmed that the establishment of settlements by Israel in these territories has no legal validity and constitutes a serious obstruction to achieving a two-state solution. It called for an immediate cessation of settlement activities and urged all parties to resume negotiations for a just and lasting peace. Resolution 2334 was notable for its adoption without a veto, as the United States abstained, allowing the measure to pass despite potential opposition. The resolution reaffirmed previous UNSC principles, including those in Resolutions 242 (1967) and 338 (1973), and highlighted the international community's commitment to the two-state solution as the basis for resolving the Israel–Palestine conflict.

B. International Law and Humanitarian Law

I. Geneva Conventions

The Geneva Conventions are a series of international treaties that form the core of international humanitarian law (IHL), governing the conduct of armed conflicts and the protection of individuals who are not or are no longer participating in hostilities. The four conventions, last comprehensively revised in 1949, establish rules for:

- 1 The treatment of wounded and sick members of armed forces in the field (First Convention).
- 2 The treatment of wounded, sick, and shipwrecked members of armed forces at sea (Second Convention).
- 3 The treatment of prisoners of war (Third Convention).
- 4 The protection of civilians in times of war, including occupied territories (Fourth Convention).

The conventions are supplemented by three additional protocols (1977 and 2005), which address issues such as protection of civilians, international and non-international conflicts, and the use of certain weapons. Adherence to the Geneva Conventions is legally binding for all state parties, including in conflicts such as the Israel–Palestine conflict, where principles like the protection of civilians, prohibition of collective punishment, and humane treatment of detainees are central to assessing compliance with international law. Violations of these conventions may constitute war crimes, subject to prosecution under international tribunals or the International Criminal Court (ICC).

II. Status of Occupied Territories

The occupied territories in the context of the Israel–Palestine conflict primarily include the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and the Gaza Strip, areas captured by Israel during the 1967 Six-Day War. Under international law, including the Fourth Geneva Convention (1949), these territories are considered occupied, meaning that the occupying power is obligated to protect the civilian population, maintain public order, and respect human rights. Israel’s establishment of settlements in the West Bank and East Jerusalem is widely regarded by the United Nations and the international community as a violation of international law, though Israel disputes this interpretation. The Gaza Strip, while Israel withdrew its permanent military presence in 2005, remains under an effective blockade, and the territory is subject to ongoing security restrictions and humanitarian concerns. The status of these territories is central to discussions on a two-state solution, refugees, borders, and the rights of Palestinians under UN resolutions 242 (1967), 338 (1973), and 2334 (2016).

V. Current Situation and Ground Realities

A. Political Landscape

I. Israel’s Government and Security Policies

Israel is a parliamentary democracy led by the Prime Minister and the Knesset. Its security policies focus on military preparedness, intelligence operations, and counterterrorism, primarily through the Israel Defense Forces (IDF). In the context of the Israel–Palestine conflict, these policies include border control, occupation management in the West Bank, and operations in Gaza. Israel maintains that these measures are necessary for national security, while critics argue they affect civilian populations and human rights, raising concerns under international law and UN resolutions.

II. Palestinian Authority and Hamas Dynamics

The Palestinian Authority (PA), established under the Oslo Accords (1993), governs parts of the West Bank and is responsible for civil administration and security coordination with Israel. Hamas, an Islamist political and militant group, controls the Gaza Strip and rejects recognition of Israel, often engaging in armed conflict with Israeli forces. The division between the PA and Hamas has led to fragmented governance, complicating peace negotiations and the implementation of a two-state solution. Security dynamics involve PA policing in the West Bank and Hamas’ military activities in Gaza, both of which are central to Israeli-Palestinian tensions and international diplomatic efforts.

B. Humanitarian Conditions

I. Gaza Strip

The Gaza Strip is a densely populated Palestinian territory on the eastern coast of the Mediterranean Sea, bordering Israel and Egypt. It has been under the control of Hamas since 2007, following internal conflict with the Palestinian Authority. The territory faces blockades, restricted movement, and recurrent conflicts with Israel, resulting in severe humanitarian challenges, including limited access to food, water, healthcare, and electricity. Gaza remains a central focus in the Israel–Palestine conflict, with repeated military escalations prompting UN interventions, ceasefire negotiations, and international humanitarian assistance.

II. West Bank and East Jerusalem

The West Bank and East Jerusalem are Palestinian territories occupied by Israel since 1967. The West Bank is partially administered by the Palestinian Authority, while Israel maintains military and settlement control over large areas. East Jerusalem, annexed by Israel, is considered occupied under international law, with Palestinians claiming it as the capital of a future state. Both areas are central to territorial disputes, settlement controversies, and negotiations for a two-state solution, with frequent clashes and ongoing international concern over human rights and access to resources.

Regional and International Implications

The Israel–Palestine conflict has **far-reaching regional and global consequences**. Regionally, it **affects stability in the Middle East**, influencing neighboring countries like **Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria**, and fueling **proxy conflicts and political tensions**. Internationally, the conflict impacts **global diplomacy, security, and humanitarian policies**, drawing involvement from the **United Nations, major powers, and international organizations**. It shapes debates on **self-determination, human rights, and international law**, while recurrent escalations often lead to **humanitarian crises, refugee flows, and strained diplomatic relations**. The conflict also influences **energy security, counterterrorism strategies, and regional alliances**, making it a **persistent global concern**.

VI. Key Stakeholders and Actors

A. Primary Parties to the Conflict

I. Israel

Israel is a parliamentary democracy with a strong emphasis on national security, maintaining control over borders, the West Bank, and access to Gaza. Its government and military policies are central to the conflict, particularly regarding settlements, military operations, and counterterrorism measures

II. Palestine

Palestinian governance is divided: the Palestinian Authority (PA) administers parts of the West Bank, while Hamas controls the Gaza Strip. The conflict centers on territorial claims, statehood recognition, and the rights of refugees, with frequent clashes and negotiations impacting both territories.

B. Regional Actors

I. Egypt

Egypt plays a key role as a mediator between Israel and Palestinian factions, particularly in Gaza ceasefires, while also sharing a border with the Gaza Strip and managing security and humanitarian access.

II. Jordan

Jordan has a significant Palestinian population and historical ties to the West Bank. It actively participates in peace negotiations and is concerned with stability, refugee management, and religious sites in Jerusalem.

III. Iran and Gulf States

- Iran supports Palestinian groups, particularly Hamas and Islamic Jihad, providing political and military backing, influencing regional power dynamics.
- Gulf States such as Saudi Arabia, UAE, and Qatar play roles in diplomacy, economic aid, and mediation, balancing relations with Israel and Palestinian factions while pursuing regional influence.

C. International Actors

I. United States

The U.S. is a key ally of Israel, providing military, economic, and diplomatic support. It plays a central role in peace negotiations, often acting as a mediator in efforts like the Oslo Accords and other diplomatic initiatives. U.S. policy decisions significantly influence UN Security Council debates and regional dynamics.

II. Russian Federation

Russia engages as a diplomatic actor and regional power, maintaining relations with both Israel and Palestinian factions. It participates in multilateral peace efforts and seeks to influence outcomes in the Middle East through political and security channels, including coordination with Syria and Iran.

III. European Union

The EU focuses on humanitarian aid, development support, and diplomatic engagement. It advocates for a two-state solution, provides funding to the Palestinian Authority and UNRWA, and supports international law and conflict resolution mechanisms in the region.

VII. Role of the United Nations and International Bodies

A. United Nations General Assembly

The UNGA provides a forum for all Member States to discuss the conflict, pass non-binding resolutions, and coordinate humanitarian and development aid. It has been instrumental in promoting international recognition of Palestinian rights and statehood.

B. United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA)

UNRWA provides humanitarian assistance, education, and health services to Palestinian refugees across the Middle East, including in Gaza, West Bank, Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria. It plays a critical role in alleviating humanitarian crises resulting from ongoing conflicts.

C. International Court of Justice (ICJ)

The ICJ provides legal guidance and advisory opinions on issues related to international law, such as the legality of settlements, occupation, and the separation barrier. Its rulings influence UN resolutions, international diplomacy, and enforcement of international humanitarian law.

VIII. Peace Initiatives and Negotiation Efforts

A. Oslo Accords

The Oslo Accords were a series of agreements between Israel and the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) aimed at establishing a framework for Palestinian self-rule in the West Bank and Gaza. They created the Palestinian Authority (PA) to govern certain areas and set the stage for future negotiations on final-status issues such as borders, refugees, and Jerusalem.

B. Camp David Agreements

The 1978 Camp David Accords were mediated by the United States, resulting in a peace treaty between Egypt and Israel, with Israel withdrawing from the Sinai Peninsula. Subsequent efforts, such as the 2000 Camp David Summit, attempted to resolve the Israel–Palestine conflict, but negotiations failed due to disagreements over Jerusalem, refugees, and borders.

C. Abraham Accords

The Abraham Accords marked the normalization of relations between Israel and several Arab states, including the United Arab Emirates and Bahrain, with economic, diplomatic, and security cooperation agreements. While not directly resolving the Israel–Palestine conflict,

these accords shifted regional alliances and influenced broader peace and diplomatic strategies in the Middle East.

IX. Case Studies

A. Gaza Ceasefire Agreements

Multiple ceasefires have been brokered between Israel and Hamas in Gaza, often mediated by Egypt, Qatar, or the UN, to halt hostilities during escalations. These agreements aim to temporarily stop violence, protect civilians, and allow humanitarian access, though they are frequently short-lived due to ongoing tensions.

B. Egypt's Mediation Efforts

Egypt plays a key mediator role in the Israel–Palestine conflict, particularly in Gaza, facilitating ceasefires, prisoner exchanges, and dialogue between Palestinian factions and Israel. Its strategic position and diplomatic influence make it central to regional conflict management.

C. UNSC Emergency Sessions

The UN Security Council convenes emergency sessions during escalations in Gaza or the West Bank to address immediate threats to peace, call for ceasefires, and coordinate international responses. While some resolutions are binding, enforcement often depends on member states' cooperation and veto dynamics.

D. Humanitarian Aid Corridors

International bodies, including the UN and UNRWA, coordinate humanitarian corridors to provide essential food, medical supplies, and relief to civilians, particularly in Gaza and conflict-affected areas of the West Bank. These corridors are critical for mitigating civilian suffering amid blockades and military operations.

X. Pathways Toward Reconciliation

A. Two-State Solution

The two-state solution envisions Israel and Palestine as independent, sovereign states coexisting peacefully within mutually recognized borders, often based on the 1967 lines with negotiated adjustments. It is widely endorsed by the UN, international community, and many regional actors as the primary framework for resolving the conflict.

B. Alternative Political Frameworks

Alternative proposals include a one-state solution with equal rights for all citizens, confederation models, or autonomous regions under shared governance. These frameworks aim

to address demographic, territorial, and security challenges where the two-state approach faces obstacles.

C. Confidence-Building Measures

These measures include ceasefires, prisoner exchanges, economic cooperation, and joint development projects, designed to reduce mistrust, prevent escalation, and create conditions for substantive negotiations between the parties.

E. Ceasefire and De-Escalation Mechanisms

Mechanisms such as mediated ceasefires, temporary truce agreements, and third-party monitoring help stop immediate violence, protect civilians, and maintain stability while longer-term political solutions are negotiated.

XI. Challenges to Achieving Reconciliation

A. Political Deadlock

Negotiations are frequently stalled due to disagreements over borders, Jerusalem, refugees, and state recognition, creating a persistent stalemate in peace efforts.

B. Security Concerns and Militancy

Ongoing attacks, rocket fire, and militant activities on both sides hinder trust and complicate the implementation of political agreements and ceasefires.

C. Settlement Expansion

The growth of Israeli settlements in the West Bank and East Jerusalem is widely viewed as a violation of international law and a major obstacle to creating a contiguous and viable Palestinian state.

D. Humanitarian Access Constraints

Blockades, movement restrictions, and security concerns in Gaza and parts of the West Bank limit access to essential goods, healthcare, and infrastructure, exacerbating civilian suffering and tension

E. Trust Deficit Between Parties

Decades of conflict, past failures of agreements, and mutual perceptions of hostility and betrayal have created a deep mistrust, making compromise and sustained reconciliation difficult.

XII. Policy Options and Solutions

A. UNSC Resolution Mechanisms

The UN Security Council can adopt binding resolutions to address conflict escalation, enforce ceasefires, call for withdrawals, and mandate negotiations. These resolutions provide a legal framework for international intervention and pressure parties to comply with international law.

B. Sanctions, Monitoring, and Peacekeeping

The UN and other international bodies can implement sanctions, deploy peacekeeping forces, and monitor conflict zones to deter violations, protect civilians, and maintain stability. Peacekeeping missions may include border monitoring, demilitarized zones, and supervision of ceasefires.

C. International Mediation Frameworks

Third-party mediation by actors such as the UN, Egypt, the United States, the EU, or regional coalitions helps facilitate negotiations, confidence-building, and dispute resolution, ensuring dialogue continues even amid tension.

D. Protection of Civilians and Human Rights

Policy options include ensuring humanitarian corridors, adherence to international law, monitoring human rights violations, and support for refugees. Protecting civilians remains central to conflict management, reconciliation, and long-term peacebuilding.

XIII. QARMA

1. What is the most viable political solution for reconciliation—Two-State, one-state, or confederation—and how should the status of Jerusalem and settlements be addressed?
2. What measures can the UNSC implement to ensure lasting ceasefires, reduce violence, and maintain peace and security for both Israelis and Palestinians?
3. How can humanitarian access, civilian protection, and human rights be guaranteed, and what role should UNRWA and international organizations play?
4. How can major powers, regional actors, and the UNSC coordinate effectively, including the use of sanctions or binding resolutions, to facilitate reconciliation?
5. What confidence-building measures, interim agreements, and community-based initiatives can restore trust and ensure sustainable political, social, and economic stability?

Agenda B: Stabilizing the Horn of Africa: Addressing the Conflict and Humanitarian Crisis in Ethiopia (Tigray region)

I. Introduction to the United Nations Security Council

Role of the UNSC in the Tigray Conflict

During the Tigray conflict in Ethiopia (2020–2022 and ongoing), the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) has primarily engaged through statements expressing concern, calls for humanitarian access, and urging an end to hostilities, reflecting its mandate to maintain international peace and security. In April 2021, the Council publicly expressed “deep concern” over the humanitarian crisis and alleged human rights violations, including widespread sexual violence and barriers to aid delivery, while urging all parties to refrain from inflammatory rhetoric, negotiate ceasefires, and allow unfettered humanitarian access. Despite these actions, the UNSC has not enacted binding resolutions, highlighting both its role in drawing international attention and encouraging dialogue and its limitations in enforcing robust political measures, particularly when consensus among permanent members is difficult.

II. Introduction to the Agenda

A. Understanding Reconciliation and Conflict Resolution in International Crises

Reconciliation and conflict resolution in international crises involve addressing the root causes of conflict, repairing relationships between conflicting parties, and establishing mechanisms to prevent future hostilities. Reconciliation emphasizes building trust, acknowledging past grievances, and promoting justice and accountability, often through diplomatic negotiations, peace agreements, and transitional justice mechanisms. Conflict resolution includes a variety of strategies, such as mediation by third parties (e.g., UN, regional organizations), ceasefires, sanctions, peacekeeping operations, and confidence-building measures. Effective reconciliation requires inclusive dialogue, protection of civilian populations, adherence to international law, and support for sustainable development, ensuring that political solutions are durable and equitable. Examples include UN-mediated negotiations in Israel–Palestine, peace processes in Tigray, and post-conflict reconciliation in Rwanda and Bosnia, which demonstrate how a combination of diplomatic, legal, and humanitarian approaches is critical to resolving crises and fostering long-term stability.

B. Scope and Significance of the Tigray Conflict

The Tigray conflict (2020–present) in northern Ethiopia is a major internal armed conflict involving the Tigray People’s Liberation Front (TPLF) and the Ethiopian federal government, with involvement from Eritrean forces and regional militias. The conflict has widespread humanitarian, political, and regional implications, resulting in tens of thousands of deaths, massive displacement, famine conditions, and human rights violations, including reports of sexual violence and attacks on civilians. Regionally, the conflict has destabilized the Horn of Africa, affecting neighboring countries like Sudan and Eritrea, and contributing to refugee flows and cross-border tensions. Internationally, it has drawn attention from the UN, African Union, and global powers, highlighting challenges in humanitarian access, conflict resolution, and enforcement of international law. The Tigray conflict underscores the complexity of

modern internal conflicts where political, ethnic, and security dynamics intersect, making reconciliation and peacebuilding efforts both urgent and challenging.

C. UNSC Jurisdiction and Limitations

The UN Security Council (UNSC) is responsible for maintaining international peace and security, including authorizing peacekeeping missions, sanctions, and binding resolutions. Its jurisdiction covers threats to peace, acts of aggression, and serious violations of international law. However, its effectiveness is limited by the veto power of the five permanent members (P5), sovereignty concerns, and resource or compliance challenges, which can hinder rapid or decisive action in conflicts like Tigray or Israel–Palestine.

III. Historical Background of the Conflict

A. Origins of the Tigray Conflict

Ethiopia’s Federal Structure and Ethnic Federalism

Ethiopia is a federal state organized under the 1995 Constitution, officially known as the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE). Its federalism is ethnically based, dividing the country into regional states (called “nations, nationalities, and peoples’ regions”) largely along ethnic lines. Each region has the right to self-administration, official language recognition, and even secession, under Article 39 of the Constitution. While this ethnic federalism was designed to protect minority rights and promote local governance, it has also intensified ethnic tensions, fueled competition over resources and political power, and contributed to conflicts such as the Tigray war, as regional and federal authorities clash over autonomy, governance, and security.

Historical Tensions between TPLF and Federal Government

The Tigray People’s Liberation Front (TPLF) was a dominant force in Ethiopia’s ruling coalition, the Ethiopian People’s Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF), from 1991 to 2018. Tensions escalated after Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed came to power in 2018, pursuing political reforms that reduced the TPLF’s influence in federal institutions. Historical grievances include disputes over political power, resource control, military authority, and regional autonomy, which culminated in the 2020–2022 Tigray conflict when federal forces and the TPLF clashed over governance, security, and Tigray’s self-rule. These longstanding tensions reflect ethnic federalism challenges and mistrust between regional and central authorities.

Previous Conflicts and Political Marginalization

The Tigray region has a history of armed conflict and political tension with Ethiopia’s federal government, stemming from the TPLF’s long dominance in federal politics (1991–2018) and subsequent marginalization under Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed. Disputes over representation,

resource allocation, and regional autonomy created persistent grievances. Prior clashes, including border skirmishes, federal interventions, and local uprisings, laid the groundwork for the 2020–2022 Tigray conflict, highlighting the impact of ethnic federalism and political exclusion on regional instability.

B. Major Escalations

I. November 2020 Onset of the Conflict

The conflict began in November 2020 when the federal government launched a military operation against the TPLF following attacks on federal military bases in Tigray. This marked the start of full-scale hostilities between federal forces and the TPLF

II. Eritrean Military Involvement

Eritrean forces intervened on the side of the Ethiopian federal government, contributing to intense fighting, reported human rights abuses, and further regional instability, including cross-border tensions with Sudan.

III. Humanitarian Crisis and Displacement

The conflict triggered a severe humanitarian crisis, with millions displaced, widespread food insecurity, and limited access to healthcare and basic services. Civilians faced attacks, sexual violence, and destruction of infrastructure, prompting calls from the UN and international community for urgent humanitarian assistance.

IV. Legal and Political Framework

A. Relevant United Nations Security Council Resolutions

I. Previous UNSC Statements on Ethiopia

The UN Security Council (UNSC) has issued statements expressing concern over the Tigray conflict, urging cessation of hostilities, protection of civilians, and unfettered humanitarian access. These statements emphasize the need for dialogue and negotiation but have not included binding enforcement measures.

II. Sanctions and Peacekeeping Mandates

While the UNSC has considered sanctions and peacekeeping operations, no formal mandates have been implemented. The Council's influence is limited by political divisions among permanent members (P5), which has constrained robust action on the ground.

B. International Law and Humanitarian Law

I. Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict

Under international humanitarian law, all parties must protect civilians, avoid targeting non-combatants, and allow safe humanitarian access. Violations, including attacks on civilians, can constitute war crimes.

II. Refugee and Human Rights Obligations

Ethiopia and the international community are bound to uphold human rights and refugee protection, providing safety, shelter, food, and medical aid to those displaced by the conflict, in accordance with the Geneva Conventions and international human rights law.

V. Current Situation and Ground Realities

A. Political Landscape

I. Ethiopian Federal Government and Policies

The federal government, led by Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, continues to assert control over Tigray while implementing security measures, political reforms, and federal mandates, aiming to stabilize the country after years of conflict.

II. Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) Dynamics

The TPLF remains a key political and military actor, controlling parts of Tigray and negotiating for autonomy and representation, contributing to ongoing tensions with the federal government.

B. Humanitarian Conditions

I. Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs)

Millions of Tigrayans have been displaced internally, living in camps with limited access to food, healthcare, and basic services.

II. Refugee Crisis in Sudan and Neighboring Countries

Large numbers of civilians have fled across borders, particularly into Sudan, creating a regional refugee crisis that strains resources and requires international humanitarian assistance.

C. Regional and International Implications

The conflict has destabilized the Horn of Africa, affecting Sudan, Eritrea, and other neighboring states. It draws international attention from the UN, African Union, and global powers, highlighting challenges in peacekeeping, humanitarian response, and diplomatic mediation, with wider consequences for regional security and development.

VI. Key Stakeholders and Actors

A. Primary Parties to the Conflict

I. Ethiopian Federal Government

Led by Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, the federal government seeks to assert control over Tigray, maintain national unity, and implement security measures, while facing challenges from insurgent activities.

II. Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF)

The TPLF remains a major political and military actor, controlling parts of Tigray, resisting federal authority, and seeking regional autonomy and representation.

B. Regional Actors

I. Eritrea

Provides military support to the federal government, contributing to the intensity of the conflict and cross-border security concerns.

II. Sudan

Hosts **refugees fleeing Tigray**, and is affected by border tensions and humanitarian pressures.

III. African Union (AU)

Acts as a **mediator and facilitator** in peace efforts, promoting **dialogue and negotiation** between parties.

C. International Actors

I. United Nations

Engaged through humanitarian assistance, peacekeeping discussions, and calls for ceasefires

II. European Union

Provides humanitarian aid, diplomatic pressure, and development assistance.

III. United States and Other Donor Nations

Support humanitarian relief, sanctions, and diplomatic mediation, influencing both regional stability and conflict resolution efforts.

VII. Role of the United Nations and International Bodies

A. United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA)

OCHA coordinates humanitarian relief operations, ensuring the delivery of food, medicine, and shelter to affected populations. It plays a central role in mobilizing international aid and monitoring access constraints.

B. African Union Peace and Mediation Efforts

The AU facilitates dialogue and negotiation between the Ethiopian federal government and the TPLF, promoting peaceful settlement, political dialogue, and reconciliation at the regional level.

C. Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) and UN Agencies

NGOs and UN agencies such as UNICEF, UNHCR, and the Red Cross provide emergency assistance, refugee support, and protection of civilians, helping alleviate the humanitarian crisis while advocating for human rights and accountability.

VIII. Peace Initiatives and Negotiation Efforts

A. African Union Mediated Talks

The African Union (AU) has been the primary regional mediator in the Tigray conflict, facilitating dialogue between the Ethiopian federal government and the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF). The AU-led talks focus on political reconciliation, negotiation

frameworks, and the promotion of peaceful solutions while emphasizing respect for Ethiopia's sovereignty and the reduction of hostilities.

B. Ceasefire Agreements

Several temporary ceasefires have been negotiated to halt fighting, protect civilians, and allow the delivery of humanitarian aid. Although these agreements are designed to reduce civilian suffering and create opportunities for dialogue, compliance has often been inconsistent, with violations reported during periods of heightened tension.

C. International Mediation Frameworks

The United Nations, European Union, and donor nations have supported peace initiatives through diplomatic engagement, coordination of humanitarian assistance, and monitoring mechanisms. These international frameworks complement regional mediation efforts by applying diplomatic pressure, assisting in humanitarian operations, and promoting long-term political solutions, highlighting the importance of regional and global cooperation in stabilizing the conflict.

IX. Case Studies

A. Humanitarian Aid Corridors

During the Tigray conflict, humanitarian aid corridors have been established to provide critical access for food, medicine, and relief supplies to civilians trapped in conflict zones. These corridors are coordinated by the United Nations, African Union, and partner NGOs, ensuring the safe delivery of humanitarian assistance despite ongoing hostilities. The corridors also aim to protect civilians, reduce suffering, and facilitate the work of humanitarian agencies, although access has often been hampered by security challenges, bureaucratic restrictions, and sporadic violations of ceasefires. The success and limitations of these corridors illustrate the importance of coordinated international and regional efforts in addressing humanitarian crises during armed conflict.

B. AU Peace and Mediation Efforts

The African Union (AU) has played a central role in mediating the Tigray conflict, acting as a regional facilitator between the Ethiopian federal government and the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF). AU-led mediation focuses on negotiating ceasefires, promoting political dialogue, and proposing frameworks for reconciliation to reduce hostilities and stabilize the region. The AU emphasizes inclusive negotiations, respect for Ethiopia's sovereignty, and protection of civilians, while coordinating with international partners to support humanitarian access and diplomatic efforts. These efforts highlight the importance of

regional engagement in conflict resolution and the AU's role in complementing international mediation mechanisms.

C. UNSC Emergency Statements and Resolutions

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) has responded to the Tigray conflict through emergency statements and press releases expressing concern over human rights violations, civilian casualties, and restricted humanitarian access. These statements urge the Ethiopian federal government, TPLF, and other parties to cease hostilities, comply with international law, and allow unhindered humanitarian assistance. While the UNSC has debated the use of sanctions or formal resolutions, political divisions among permanent members have limited the adoption of binding enforcement measures. Nevertheless, these interventions highlight the Council's role in raising international awareness, promoting accountability, and encouraging dialogue, complementing regional and humanitarian efforts in mitigating the crisis.

D. Regional Stabilization Projects

Regional stabilization projects aim to mitigate the wider impact of the Tigray conflict on neighboring countries and promote long-term security and development in the Horn of Africa. Countries like Sudan have been directly affected by large refugee inflows, prompting initiatives to provide shelter, food, and medical assistance while coordinating with the UN, NGOs, and donor nations. Cross-border cooperation has also focused on enhancing security, preventing arms trafficking, and supporting displaced populations. These projects highlight the importance of regional collaboration and international support in stabilizing the conflict environment, reducing humanitarian crises, and facilitating pathways toward peace and reconstruction.

X. Pathways Toward Stabilization

A. Political Dialogue and Reconciliation

Stabilization begins with negotiations between the Ethiopian federal government and the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) to address political grievances, ensure fair representation, and rebuild trust. Dialogue and reconciliation efforts aim to create a foundation for long-term peace and prevent future conflicts.

B. Peacebuilding and Reconstruction Programs

These programs focus on rebuilding infrastructure, restoring public services, and providing support for internally displaced persons and affected communities. Such initiatives are essential for re-establishing normalcy and fostering socio-economic development in Tigray and surrounding regions.

C. Confidence-Building Measures

Measures such as humanitarian access guarantees, prisoner exchanges, and community engagement initiatives help reduce tensions, build mutual trust, and facilitate cooperation between conflicting parties.

D. Ceasefire and De-Escalation Mechanisms

Structured ceasefire agreements and monitoring mechanisms are critical to halting hostilities, preventing escalation, and creating space for sustained dialogue and peace negotiations.

XI. Challenges to Achieving Stability

A. Political Deadlock and Ethnic Tensions

Persistent disagreements between the Ethiopian federal government and the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF), combined with Ethiopia's ethnic federalism, have created political deadlock and heightened ethnic tensions, obstructing efforts toward reconciliation and governance.

B. Security Concerns and Militancy

Ongoing armed clashes, the presence of militias, and sporadic violence continue to threaten civilian safety and hinder stabilization efforts, complicating the implementation of peace agreements.

C. Refugee and Humanitarian Access Constraints

Millions of displaced people in Tigray and neighboring countries, including Sudan, face limited access to food, medical care, and shelter, while humanitarian corridors are often obstructed due to insecurity or bureaucratic restrictions.

D. Trust Deficit Between Parties

A deep lack of trust between the federal government and the TPLF undermines negotiations, delays ceasefire implementation, and hampers cooperation on reconstruction and peacebuilding initiatives.

E. Regional Spillover Risks

The conflict has regional implications, including refugee flows, cross-border tensions, and security concerns in neighboring countries, which complicate stabilization efforts and require coordinated regional and international responses.

XII. Policy Options and Solutions

A. UNSC Resolution Mechanisms

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) can adopt resolutions calling for ceasefires, political dialogue, and humanitarian access, providing a formal international framework to address the conflict and guide member states' actions.

B. Peacekeeping and Monitoring Missions

Deployment of UN or AU peacekeeping forces and monitoring teams can help observe ceasefire compliance, protect civilians, and support stability, ensuring that agreements are implemented effectively on the ground.

C. Sanctions and Diplomatic Pressure

The international community can employ targeted sanctions, travel bans, and diplomatic engagement to influence conflicting parties, deter human rights violations, and encourage political negotiations and adherence to international law.

D. Protection of Civilians and Humanitarian Support

Ensuring the safety of civilians through protective measures, along with coordinated humanitarian aid, is essential to alleviate suffering, provide basic needs, and maintain social stability, complementing political and security initiatives.

XIII. QARMA

1. How can the **Ethiopian federal government and the TPLF** be encouraged to engage in meaningful political dialogue and reconciliation?
2. What measures can regional actors, such as the **African Union and neighboring countries**, implement to support peace and stabilization in Tigray?
3. How can the **UN Security Council** and international community ensure **compliance with ceasefire agreements** and reduce violations?
4. What strategies can be used to **guarantee safe humanitarian access** for internally displaced persons and refugees in Tigray and neighboring countries?
5. How can civilians be **protected from human rights violations and armed attacks** while ensuring accountability for perpetrators?
6. What **confidence-building measures and reconstruction programs** can be implemented to foster **long-term stability and trust** between conflicting parties?
7. How can the **regional spillover effects**, including refugee crises and cross-border tensions, be managed through coordinated international and regional efforts?

Bibliography:

1. United Nations Charter (Articles 24, 25, 27, 39–42)
<https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/full-text>
2. UN Security Council – Role, Powers, and Overview
<https://www.un.org/securitycouncil/content/role-and-powers>
<https://www.un.org/securitycouncil/content/overview>
3. UN Security Council Resolutions (242, 338, 2334)
<https://www.un.org/securitycouncil/content/resolutions>
4. United Nations Peacekeeping (UNTSO and General Missions)
<https://peacekeeping.un.org/en/mission/united-nations-truce-supervision-organization>
<https://www.un.org/peacekeeping>
5. United Nations Peacebuilding and Reconciliation
<https://www.un.org/peacebuilding>
<https://www.un.org/en/chronicle/article/reconciliation-and-conflict-prevention>
6. UN Information System on the Question of Palestine (UNISPAL)
<https://www.un.org/unispal>
7. League of Nations Mandate for Palestine (1922)
<https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/full-text>
8. UN General Assembly Resolution 181 (1947)
<https://www.un.org/unispal/document/auto-insert-178945/>
9. Fourth Geneva Convention (1949)
<https://www.un.org/en/genocideprevention/geneva-conventions>
10. United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA)
<https://www.unrwa.org>
11. International Court of Justice (ICJ)
<https://www.icj-cij.org>
12. Palestinian Authority Official Website
<https://www.palestinecabinet.gov.ps/>
13. Hamas Background (BBC)
<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-133315>
14. International Crisis Group – Israel–Palestine
<https://www.crisisgroup.org/middle-east-north-africa/eastern-mediterranean/israelpalestine>
15. UN News – Tigray Conflict Overview
<https://news.un.org/en/story/2021/04/1089942>
16. UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) – Ethiopia
<https://www.unocha.org/ethiopia>
17. UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) – Tigray Refugees
<https://www.unhcr.org/>
18. Human Rights Watch – Ethiopia and Tigray
<https://www.hrw.org/africa/ethiopia>
<https://www.hrw.org/news/2021/07/02/un-security-council-end-inaction-ethiopia>
19. International Crisis Group – Ethiopia / Tigray
<https://www.crisisgroup.org/africa/horn-africa/ethiopia>
20. BBC – Tigray Conflict Background and Timeline
<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-africa-54805088>
21. Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia Constitution (1995)
<https://www.refworld.org/docid/3ae6b5a84.html>

22. African Union Peace and Security Council
<https://au.int/en/peace-and-security>
23. UN Security Council Press Releases and Emergency Statements
<https://www.un.org/securitycouncil/content/press-releases>